

World Class Student Essay

In order to put my behaviors and goals as an engineering student into perspective I have put together the following paper. I will be reviewing a variety of areas that typical engineering students should be proficient at. In each section I will lay out the behaviors and skills that I would expect a “world class” engineering student to have. I will then discuss how I feel my performance is in the same areas. Finally, to summarize each section, I will lay out what I can do that will help me reach my goal. Some of these skills or behaviors may be redundant from section to section. However, I think that it is important to include the item in every instance in order for me to be able to review this paper and to evaluate my progress.

Goal Setting

Setting Goals

Out there somewhere is a student that has it all planned out. They know the major that they want to graduate with and they have a plan to get there. This person would have a timeline that they monitor constantly to keep on track. Their classes would be planned a year or more in advance. They would visit their professor to make sure that they were setting the right academic goals. Aspirations at the “world class” level are high, so this person would definitely be looking for a 4.0 GPA. This means that they would have a backup plan and/or support system to help reach their goals. I would expect someone like this to have a career goal in mind as well. Some of these students may have a specific goal to reach a certain position in a certain company or organization.

I would say I’m pretty sure of my goals. Being that I am older than the average college student I feel like I’m under the gun so to speak. I know that I have to have firm goals. I also know that I have some making up to do. In that sense a large portion of my goals are set for me. Since I was a kid I have wanted to work in the aerospace industry. I am hoping that my engineering degree will lead me that way. Since I am “old” compared to most of my peers I am a bit more pragmatic. I have worked in the electronics industry for well over a decade now. I have decided that a degree in electrical engineering is probably going to give me the best opportunities given my experience. In life my goals are quite simple since I have a family. Provide them all with the best life possible. The goal is simple. Execution is another story.

In order for me to become closer to “world class” I will need to fine tune my goals. I would like to start setting up more short term goals. In fact, this term I have several goals. First, I have a weekly study goal of 8-10 hours in the Math Lab. I will probably change this based on my grades. This is a real challenge with my schedule. My bigger goal is to feel less stressed for tests. I will also be trying to do more on campus. Using the math lab as well as meeting with my teachers was very helpful last year but I have fallen away from that this term. By adding these smaller goals I will strengthen my larger goals of graduating with a high GPA. I also need to investigate options and opportunities to shorten my timeline. In general, I need to be more proactive.

Strengthening & Clarifying Commitment to Goals

A “world class” student would be reviewing their goals regularly. In order to strengthen their goals, short term goals would be added. Commitment to your goals is the key to success. A “world class” student keeps his or her eye on the prize and does their best to maintain a positive attitude. This means utilizing school groups and peers to help reinforce your goals. Setting similar goals with other engineering students and encouraging each other will surely help.

I have met with my engineering professor and I have my primary educational and career goals figured out. I rely heavily on my family for support and they help to remind me of why reaching my goals is so important. I definitely could use some fine tuning of my goals. I should be reviewing my goals and my progress on a more regular basis. I will find an app for that (or use my calendar).

Setting up a Road Map a Plan to Guide Me to Graduation

A “world class” student would have a solid plan in place for all aspects of their life. Of course there is always room for improvement and plans change. Their plan would include employment preparation like building a network and a resume. Of course the student’s life would revolve around school instead of school around the rest of their life. This means that social and work life would likely be school related. The key to their road map would be time management.

I am working on my plan. I am not the average community college student since I run a business and manage my household while getting my education. I also don’t know if a typical student would be thinking about retirement options like I do. I do very well with long term

planning however my short term planning is often disrupted by my crazy life. I also sometimes find myself crunching to accomplish my goals. There are some benefits to being older. I already have a great network that is constantly growing. As a manager and small business owner, I also have a great resume that could very easily be applied to most engineering professions.

But still, I am too unusual of a case to be “world class”. With a teenage daughter and a 10 year old son there is just no way. To be the best student I can be I will need to set up a plan that allow for more quality study time especially since classes are only going to get harder. I’m going to set up goals to make more “study buddies”. I need to spend more time coming up with and going over short term goals. I will also set up more precise benchmarks in my plan during which I can reflect and adjust my plan. I should see it become easier to achieve long term goals.

Understanding the Essence of Engineering

To be a “world class” engineering student one would need to understand all of the aspects of what it means to be an engineer. This means that this individual would need to know a lot more than just the different types of engineers. They would need to be able to identify what educational requirements and licensure requirements there are. This person would need to understand the responsibilities both ethically, to the public, and to their employer. I feel like even a world class engineering student would probably miss some of the full essence until they are employed.

I have a good idea of the responsibility and basic skills associated with being an engineer. As I have found in Engineering 111, I still have a lot to learn. I would say that I am a good 80% on my way to understanding the *essence* of this career thanks partly to this class. I would like to spend some time working with engineers in order to get a better idea of the full scope. I guess that the best way to do this is to get an internship. I also need to be a good listener and pick the brains of individuals that I encounter that are in the field.

Community Building

Building Relationships and Making Effective Use of My Peers

Since a “world class” student would spend a majority of their time on campus, this student would likely be a regular in the math lab. It is also likely that they would be tutoring their peers. These students build their own study groups and communicate regularly with their professors. Somehow these students are also able to find time work and will try to have an internship so that they can build up some work experience.

I would say that I have a couple of advantages and a few disadvantages. I have been very good at utilizing the math lab. I also have had several study groups for different classes. Owning my own business for 11 years has given me a bit of an edge also. I have work experience and a much more developed network than a typical student. My primary focus will probably be building contacts in the engineering community. Even though I have a slight advantage since I am older, I need to realize that I can learn a lot from these “kids”. I also need to spend more time with my professors not only getting help but also asking career based questions.

Participating in Co-Curricular Activities

The “world class” student is involved in multiple clubs and participates in most school activities. While “world class” student is probably involved in organizing these activities and not just participating, I am resigned to the fact that I will never be “world class” in this category. I have got way too full of a schedule. My family will end up taking precedent over co-curricular activities. I am also older than most of my fellow students. This makes for a little awkwardness, although less than what I expected. I am hoping that I will have an easier time with my schedule when I work less as I get further along in my degree. As I mentioned, I will spend more time on campus and this means that I will probably participate in something I am just not sure I can commit to these activities.

Academic Development- Navigating the Community College and University Systems

In this area I feel a little closer to “world class”. I have met with advisors and know what resources are available to me. I am feeling very confident in navigating CCC’s website. I know the layout of the campus. I have a good deal of experience with the Math Lab. I know where to find virtually any information that I need. I definitely could spend more time on campus utilizing these resources. I am a little less proficient than I would like to be when it comes to Portland State. If I was a “world class” student I would probably be better prepared for PSU. I have

checked out their website and have looked over their programs. I will make it a goal to do two things to improve my knowledge of the school over the Christmas break. I will spend some time looking more thoroughly into my classes and where they will be. I will also get the transfer portion of my degree figured out including a more firm decision on when I will be looking to transfer. This will get me a little closer to where I would like to be. "World Class"!

Personal Development

Enhancing Self Awareness and Improving Skills to Practice Academic Success Strategies

I would hope that a world class student would constantly be analyzing both their strengths and weaknesses and regularly develop plans to improve their skills as needed. They would probably set clear goals for improvement just as they would educational goals.

Believe me. I am aware of my flaws. I have plans in place to improve myself in all aspects of my life. I feel like it should be everyone's goal to be the best individual that we can be. This is what makes the world a better place. I am always looking to improve my study skills. Currently I am working on problem solving strategies. I have slipped a bit this term with my study time but I feel like I am getting back on track. I will definitely be open to advice and perhaps I will take some classes (online, or in school) to help me with note taking and time management. My wife is a big fan of lists. I will try making a few and see if it helps. In order to increase my self-awareness I think I will challenge myself to do something better every day. An example would be, "I am going to read an extra chapter today". This will force me to think about what I do that could be improved, and hopefully create some good behaviors

Outlining What Attitudes and Behaviors I Need to Change or Add to be Successful

A "world class" student would have most of their behaviors figured out. I think that they would mostly be fine tuning their daily routines. They would set aside study time, both with and without groups. They would spend time on campus to immerse themselves fully in their education. Why would attitudes need changing if they are excited about their decision to become an engineer?

I am excited to go to school so attitude is really only an issue on test day. I have committed to spending more time studying. I also have decided to spend more time on campus. This helped

in the past. I just haven't made as much time this term. I also need to procrastinate less. I like to be able to mull things over and not procrastinating will almost certainly improve my grades.

Managing Time and Tasks

A "world class" student would constantly refer to the syllabus to know what's coming. They would look over assignments in advance to know what was going to be difficult. Time would be spent on campus for the most part. I'm sure they would use the calendar on their phone or computer and set up alerts to remind them of *upcoming* tasks, not just the ones that are happening next. With a full schedule, every day would probably be almost as busy as mine.

I'm pretty good with scheduling. Since I have kids I have to be. This does not mean that I manage my time as wisely as I could. In some instances, I will just have to be stressed. In other instances I procrastinate. I have been doing better at not procrastinating but I am by no means perfect. Most of my instructors are posting on assignments, notes, and other useful stuff on Moodle. This has made it much easier to track assignments and things. I have been able to be much more proactive. I should probably just try to schedule my entire week with every detail. I will include meals, study time, kid time, etc. That is kind of a scary thought. I also would like to spend more time exploring problems rather than just completing assignments. This will probably take a while so I should schedule accordingly.

Engaging in Good Health and Wellness Practices Including Management of Stress

The "world class" student would likely be a pillar of good health. They would probably exercise on campus or with school pals. Since they would be perfectly comfortable and caught up on assignments their stress would be minimal. With no kids and minimal bills, eating healthy would probably be the most difficult thing they did.

I get plenty of exercise. When Christmas break is here I will really release some stress on the mountain. In the meantime I walk the dog and play ball with my kids. There is also no shortage of projects around my house. At this point chores feel a little less like work than they used to. I am a fairly health conscious individual. I try to eat healthy even when eating convenience food. I hike and ride my bike when I have time. I could probably do more to relieve stress. I think that putting more time toward studying will help but I probably should try to take breaks and recuperate a little. I think I will try to ask some other graduates who may have similar

situations to me and see if they can offer some good advice. I doubt that anything will help to alleviate the stress of a teenage daughter.

Conclusion

While writing this paper I came up with a few consistent themes. I found that time management and participation on campus appear to be extremely important to my goals as a student. I also consistently found myself repeating that if I studied more I would be less stressed and my life would be easier. While I am sure that these things are true for most students, I find it interesting that the same items affect so many different areas of my development as student. I also realized that frequent revisiting of ones goals is essential to success. With several new goals in mind I will now have to create plans and fine tune my larger goals. That is how I will become a “world class” engineering student.